Farmer Corn Brief

Week of October 29, 2026

> **Week of October 29, 2026**
> Nearby corn: $4.513/bu (-$0.092 (-2.0%) week)
> Narrative created: October 30, 2026

Nearby futures from Yahoo Finance. Nearby corn is the market's current perception of yield and demand risk.

Contract	Last	Week change	As of
Nearby corn	$4.513/bu	-$0.092 (-2.0%)	October 29, 2026
RBOB gasoline	$3.185/gal	+0.009 (+0.3%)	October 29, 2026
Henry Hub	$2.952/MMBtu	+0.156 (+5.6%)	October 29, 2026

Where we are

USDA's October balance sheet remains the controlling crop regime: **16.034 billion bushels at 181.2 bushels per acre**, with projected 2026/27 ending stocks of **1.849 billion bushels**. Nebraska remains at **188 bushels per acre and 1.807 billion bushels**. (USDA WAOB, *WASDE-676*, October 9, 2026; USDA NASS, *Crop Production*, October 9, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

Harvest accelerated. The United States advanced **16 points to 60% harvested**, versus a 66% five-year average. Nebraska jumped **18 points to 55%**, still nine points behind average. Nebraska had 6.1 suitable fieldwork days. The crop is moving again, even if the calendar remains late. (USDA NASS, *Crop Progress*, October 26, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

Nearby and new-crop December are now the same contract. Nearby corn finished at **$4.513 per bushel**, down **9.2 cents**, or **2.0%**, from October 22. March was **$4.6475**, leaving **13.5 cents of December-to-March carry**—about 4.5 cents per month before interest, shrink, handling and aeration. (Farms.com, *Corn Prices and Market Data*, October 29, 2026) (farms.com)

The week in one page

- **The heavier-crop regime survived a USDA correction.** NASS corrected its September Nebraska yield from 177 to **182 bushels**, but explicitly reviewed and retained October's **188-bushel Nebraska yield and 181.2-bushel national yield**. The correction changed the comparison, not the current supply estimate.
- **The board took away another 9.2 cents.** Nearby December closed at $4.513. The market is not paying you to reject USDA's October crop yet. The November survey must prove the crop is smaller.
- **Harvest flow increased, but selected processor basis improved.** October bids were about **18 under at Cargill Blair, 21 under at Green Plains Central City and 32 under at ADM Columbus**. Blair and Central City were roughly 10 cents firmer than last week's implied basis, while broad eastern country bids remained much weaker.
- **Ethanol demand improved modestly.** Production rose 2.7% to **1.083 million barrels per day**, while national stocks were essentially unchanged at **24.523 million barrels**. That supports the local buyer, though a Midwest inventory increase limits urgency.
- **Export sales were respectable, not sufficient.** Weekly sales totaled **1.304 million metric tons**, but cumulative commitments remain **34% behind last year** and 5% below the five-year average.
- **Verdict:** This week made it harder to raise the average sale price. Basis improved at a few plants, but the board removed 9.2 cents. Protect rebounds and sell firm basis when a buyer offers it.

Exposure	Current signal	Change from last week	Time horizon	Marketing read
Unpriced 2026 crop	December at $4.513	Down 9.2 cents	Immediate	Use rebounds or floors; do not wait solely for a USDA reversal
Harvest basis	Processor bids vary from 18 to 32 under	Selectively firmer	Harvest–December	Sell firm plant basis; leave poor country basis open
Storage	13.5-cent Dec–March carry	Slightly narrower	Through March	Bin only against a cash spread that covers ownership
Ethanol bid	Higher run rate, flat national stocks	Modestly better	Two to four weeks	Supportive, not a statewide chase

Exposure	Current signal	Change from last week	Time horizon	Marketing read signal

1. USDA corrected September but left the current crop untouched

What happened

NASS found that incorrect acreage weights had been used to combine irrigated and nonirrigated objective-yield observations in September. The corrected September yields are **182 bushels for Nebraska**, up five; **118 for Kansas**, down three; and **178.8 nationally**, up 0.3. NASS said it reviewed and validated the October procedures and left the current forecasts unchanged. (USDA NASS, *Additional Information Regarding September Crop Production Notice*, October 24, 2026) (nass.usda.gov)

That means Nebraska's October increase was six bushels—from the corrected 182 to 188—not the previously reported eleven. It makes the October jump less extreme. It does **not** remove any bushels from the current balance sheet.

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

The correction raises legitimate uncertainty ahead of November, especially where strong irrigated fields are masking weak dryland corn. But uncertainty is not the same as a bullish revision. December's 9.2-cent weekly decline shows the market still trades the 188-bushel Nebraska estimate and 16.034-billion-bushel national crop.

What to do with it

2026 crop: Do not make a panic sale after another break. Do not rebuild a large open futures position because September was corrected. Price another increment on rebounds and keep weak basis separate.

Stored old-crop: The correction offers no reason to continue carrying 2025 corn. Sell firm basis and stop competing with new-crop supplies.

Watch next

USDA releases Crop Production and WASDE on **November 10 at 11 a.m. Central**. That report must lower yield, harvested acres or both before the board has a supply reason to recover. (USDA NASS, *November 2026 Reports Calendar*, accessed October 29, 2026) (data.nass.usda.gov)

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2. Harvest accelerated, but processor basis separated from the countryside

What happened

Nebraska harvest advanced from 37% to **55%**, narrowing but not closing the gap with normal. Despite heavier movement, October processor bids were approximately **$4.34 at Blair, $4.31 at Central City and $4.20 at Columbus**. Against December futures, those bids were roughly 18, 21 and 32 cents under, respectively. December-delivery bids calculated near 4 to 11 under. (Farmbucks, *CVA Nebraska Cash Bids*, updated October 29, 2026) (farmbucks.com)

Broad country basis remains weaker. USDA's October 28 ranges included **56 to 38 under in eastern Nebraska** and **45 to 20 under centrally**, while northwest bids ranged from even money to 40 over. Nebraska remains several distinct cash markets. (USDA AMS data, *Nebraska Daily Elevator Grain Bids*, October 28, 2026) (cashcorn.com)

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

The basis story improved more than the futures story. A plant at 18 under is worth rewarding while an elevator at 45 under is not. Faster harvest has not created a statewide basis collapse, but neither has it produced a broad shortage.

Posted spot-to-March cash spreads were roughly **18 to 32 cents** at the three processors. Only 13.5 cents comes from board carry. The rest depends on the buyer's basis schedule.

What to do with it

On the combine: Sell a strong processor or feed bid. Where basis is 35 to 50 under, set futures separately or use economical storage.

In the bin: Compare the actual March cash bid with today's cash bid. Do not roll automatically. The buyer must cover interest, shrink and handling.

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3. Ethanol run time improved without a national stock build

What happened

EIA reported ethanol production of **1.083 million barrels per day**, up 28,000, or 2.7%. Midwest production rose 29,000 to **1.029 million barrels per day**. National inventories declined only 35,000 barrels to **24.523 million**, while Midwest inventories increased 145,000 to 9.797 million. (EIA, *Weekly Ethanol Plant Production*, released October 28, 2026; EIA, *Stocks of Fuel Ethanol*, released October 28, 2026) (eia.gov)

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

Plants consumed corn at a better pace, and national ethanol stocks did not build with the higher output. That is modestly supportive to the plant bid. The Midwest stock increase keeps it from being a reason to expect every plant to chase.

What to do with it

Shop ethanol plants daily. Reward the 18- to 21-under bid. Where the plant remains 30 under or worse, keep futures and basis separate. Stronger production supports basis; it does not recover the board's nine-cent loss.

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4. Export sales helped demand credibility but remain behind the target

What happened

Corn export sales were **1.304 million metric tons**, down from 1.527 million the prior week but 32% above the recent four-week average. Total 2026/27 commitments reached **23.50 million tons**, or about **925 million bushels**—28% of USDA's 3.300-billion-bushel forecast. Commitments remain 34% behind last year and 5% below the five-year average. (USDA FAS, *Weekly Export Sales*, October 29, 2026; Daily Commodity Wire, *USDA Weekly Export Sales*, October 29, 2026) (fas-prod.azureedge.us)

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

Exports are buying corn. They are not yet buying enough to force the market away from a 1.849-billion-bushel carryout. One solid week is supporting evidence, not a new price regime.

What to do with it

Use export-driven bounces to price corn. Do not leave stored bushels fully open on the assumption that foreign demand will erase the October supply increase.

The crop you still have to market

Stored 2025 corn: Clear firm basis. The September stocks increase, 16-billion-bushel new crop and modest carry all argue against another routine roll.

2026 corn on the combine or in the bin: Sell strong plant basis. Where cash bids remain deeply under, protect futures separately and demand a measurable deferred return before storing.

RMA's running conventional corn harvest price was approximately **$4.79 as of October 28**, versus the **$4.62 projected price**, with one settlement remaining in the discovery period. That helps an insured yield loss under RP. It does not price normal-yield bushels. (USDA RMA, *February 2026 Price Discovery Prices*, March 2026; AGSIST, *2026 Harvest Price Tracker*, accessed October 29, 2026) (rma.usda.gov)

Bottom line

USDA admitted a September weighting error, but it did not lower the current crop. The board confirmed that distinction by losing **9.2 cents to $4.513**.

The cash decision improved selectively. Sell firm ethanol-plant basis. Keep poor country basis open. Store only where the full cash spread covers ownership. Use board rebounds to protect more confirmed production, and make the November 10 USDA report prove the crop is smaller before rebuilding a bullish position.